



Car, destruct yourself

Can self-driving cars self-destruct itself in extreme circumstances where a crash in unavoidable? <http://dgit.in/CrSlfDst>



Watch Netflix offline

It is finally (almost and maybe here). With the next major update roll out, Netflix might allow you to watch offline. <http://dgit.in/NetfOff>

Geek Life

ries have been included into “smart” devices, including smartwatches, smart homes and smart cars. Each of these platforms have different configurations, and hence need a system complicated yet reliable enough to function optimally with them.

With a combination of all these factors, it is quite evident that voice assistants have risen to their present level of efficiency. Let us have a deeper look at each of these platforms.

Apple - Siri

Since its introduction in October 14, 2011 on the iPhone 4S, Siri has virtually been integrated into the entire Apple ecosystem, except OS X. Let us accept it, even if Google got to voice recognition first, it was this witty talking assistant on the iPhone that suddenly made voice assistants popular. So much so, that Siri now has a pop-culture significance with respect to virtual assistants, enough to be featured in a Marvel movie!

Setting up Siri is quite easy, where it asks you to speak a couple of statements and also to set the voice gender, location and your nickname. Once that's done you are good to go. Although Siri has a lot of interesting features, we could not test a number of them as they were unsupported in India. Keeping that aside, Siri has a really high accuracy when it comes to detecting english and almost never mistakens what you said, even in a moderately noisy environment.

Considering the richness of the conversation, Siri does give natural replies especially for common queries like the ones about weather. But where Siri currently stumbles is understanding the context of two queries following each other, which is one more thing Google Now excels in, even up to more than five queries. Only rarely were we able to get Siri to understand a reply that referred to something from the previous reply and they were mostly from list results.

If we were to look at the features showcased at WWDC, where Apple announced the launch of Siri on macOS Sierra, the successor to OS X, it definitely looks like Siri is set to be a lot more capable than it is currently. The queries that were directed at it were quite complicated and contextual in nature and Siri did not falter with any of those. If only Apple launched its features at the same time in India.

Android - Google Now

In the group of virtual assistants that are getting better and better at having conversations with you, Google's combination of Google Now and “Ok Google” is comparatively silent. No, it doesn't do that to contemplate your personality better! As of now, Google's virtual assistant relies more on Google's own search power to solve a host of queries. There are a number of ways you can access this depending on the version of Android your phone is running. Lollipop detects “Ok Google” from any screen and launches the search app, unless you explicitly turn this feature off. We should inform you that keeping this enabled has reportedly caused some OEM phones to have microphone problems. Considering



Google hasn't yet announced any services that will be integrated with Google Home

Marshmallow, the latest version until N goes out of beta, “Google Now on Tap” is another feature that allows the launching of Google Now over any screen, giving relevant information pertaining to whatever is displayed on the screen at that moment. For example, if you are having a conversation with a friend about going to a movie, launching Now on Tap will show you the showtimes of the movie from theatres around you, the movie's rating on IMDB, and allow you to set a reminder to buy the tickets, all within the cards that pop-up when you long-tap the home button. Clicking on the various app icons (Facebook, Twitter, Youtube etc) will launch the particular app (if installed) or open the relevant webpage with relevant

content (the Facebook page or Twitter account of the movie, the YouTube trailer etc). Although this isn't strictly voice, it is definitely one of the best ways a virtual assistant can be used and activating this through voice (“Ok Google” anyone?) is just one step away for the prolific developers at Mountain View.

Google Now supports speech recognition in multiple languages including some regional Indian languages, but Now on tap only supports English, Japanese, German, Spanish, Italian, French, Korean, Portuguese, or Russian. “Ok Google” has one of the best regional language detections and offers really intuitive features without you having to explicitly enable or configure them. If only it could tell you a joke!

Special Note: Google Assistant, announced at Google I/O 2016 aims to be the spiritual successor to Google Now, taking Google's AI conversational. Two products have been announced with Google Assistant support - Google Home, an Amazon Echo inspired home assistant speaker from Google and Allo, a whatsapp like messaging app that will combine bots and voice commands.

Windows - Cortana

Due to the persistent comparisons between the three, it might be hard to accept that Cortana has been around for just two years and not more. Microsoft launched Cortana at the Microsoft BUILD Developer conference in April 2014, and if you really don't know the inspiration behind the name yet, you need to reassess your gaming creds. The name was inspired by a synthetic intelligence character in Microsoft's Halo franchise and the virtual assistant has been voiced by the same voice actor for the US-English specific version.

Microsoft has integrated Cortana into its entire ecosystem, including Windows 10, Windows 10 Mobile, Windows Phone 8.1, Microsoft Band, Xbox One and even launched apps for iOS and Android (although the Android version is in early access right now for India). Cortana has the usual features like its competitors do and can set reminders, show search results, read out the weather and more, all in natural language queries. Apart from this, you have access to Notebook, where